The Fish Story

By Naomi Wallace

(A young girl is telling a story. She has a lure box with her)

GIRL: [I remember the day] I landed a four-pound small-mouthed bass. Almost snapped my line. It took me fifteen minutes to bring that monster close enough to the bank so my father could scoop it up in the net. Daddy and I skinned it right there and cooked it over the fire. I can tell you I was proud that day. And Daddy was proud of me too. Have you ever made your father proud of you? I mean, [really, really] proud?

INTRODUCTION

This is "The Fish Story" by Naomi Wallace

GIRL: It was almost like they knew they were going to be crucified. First they would like still on your palm, as though dead. Only a slight tremor, at one end or the other, gave their trick away. It was this moment. This moment of clam right before it happened, that I liked most, when their tender, fleshy bodies studded with black dirt, would lay in my hand like the trust of an old friend. At seven years old, that glistening body of plumped worminess was more beautiful to me than any . . . . *(Breaks off).*

But when the hook came up close, the thing would start to writhe like all hell-fire was upon it. *(Beat)* It isn't true that worms wriggle when they're threaded on the hook. Those who say they do never hooked a worm in their life. No, worms don't wriggle, they writhe.

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It didn't bother my father. He'd just pluck the worm from the jar and thread it on the hook without blinking an eye. When he wasn't looking, I'd whisper "hush, hush" to the worm and when it turned its stomach to me, that pink ban that circles its body like a wedding ring, I'd strike fast, straight through the center *(She opens the box and carefully lays out some lures).*

No one made me do it but myself and for while I felt sorry for the worms, I loved hauling in the bass. And me and my father would stand side by side, casting the deep stream pools. We'd bet on who would holler first "I got one!"

Daddy was my friend. He liked fishing the way I liked it. When he cast a good one, his lips would go white and his chin would tremble just a little as he waited for a strike. Sometimes one of his ears would go red with all that waiting. Not both of them, just the left one. Red as a worm.

(Singing) Oh my love is like a red, red worm. Once I hooked that red ear. I was fly fishing and I hauled back to snap the line and toss it on a new patch of water and *(Beat. She screams as though she were her father.)* That's how he sounded. *(She polishes some lures)*

I didn't know at first what had happened so I kept jerking at the rod until my Daddy caught hold of my line with his free hand and jerked back; the rod flew out of my hands and snapped in two on the ground between us. And there hung my fly with three hooks, one hook embedded in that red ear which was redder than I'd ever seen it. He made me get it out. He didn't say a word, just opened his lure box, took out a pair of pliers and handed them to me. *(Beat)* When a bluegill swallows an artificial fly or a spinner, it usually hooks down into its lungs.

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You see, bluegills have small mouths and what does in doesn't come out. If it isn't your favorite lure, you can cut the line and throw the fish back in. They say the creek water will rust a hook out of a fish's mouth in forth-eight hours. If it's your favorite lure, and one time it was my favorite, you just have to pull. That's when a piece of the lung will come out with the hook. *(Beat)* But an ear isn't a fish. And yet my father's ear was tougher than a catfish lip. I had to twist and pull. Twist and pull. The ear fought me. It wouldn't let go. It held on tight. My father just sat there and I knew if I didn't get it out, if he had to do it himself, then . . . well, twist and pull. Twist and pull. Finally it tore. The ear. And out the hook came.

He let me choose. My father was good about that. He said I could have a spanking, without my shorts on, or eat a worm as my punishment for not looking behind me when I'd swung the rod. So I dug down into the jar and pulled one out, praying I'd grab a dead one. But that worm must have been sleeping 'cause the moment it got near my mouth it sparked like a firecracker trying to get loose. *(Beat)* Well, I looked at the worm and if a worm can look, it did so at me. I'd never had one before, thought once my Daddy let me choose between biting the tail off a grasshopper or not watching television for two whole weeks when I spilled a can of paint in the garage. I went for the grasshopper. Like a saltine cracker, almost exactly, when I ate it *(She hangs the lures on her outstretched arm as she speaks until they hand like decorations in a row.)*

They say a worm has seven hearts and that if you cut it in the right places, two or three of the pieces will live. The problem was, I didn't know where the hearts were or where to bite. I held it up to the light but I couldn't see anything but red worm. I put it halfway into my mouth. I figured biting it halfway was a

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choice. Random would kill it for sure. I closed my eyes but I couldn't bite down. The half of the worm that was inside started tickling the roof of my mouth like how the dentist does. I started to laugh but then Daddy started shouting for me to do it. He was saying "Now, now, now" *(Beat)*

Then Daddy slapped me on the back of the head and I bit down.

I only use artificials now. I like the sound of their names: Switchback, Rapala, Zarco spinner, Bass magnet, Zephyr Puppy, Double-headed jig, and Jitterbug. Twelve-pound line. Eight-pound line. Six-pound line. I was using four-pound line later that day. I cast my line right between a fallen tree and rock ledge. It fell on the water with hardly a splash. I twitched the line once. Twice. Just before the third twitch and reel, the bass struck it.

There must have been some magic to the flesh of that worm I ate because that afternoon I landed a four-pound small-mouthed bass. Almost snapped my line. It took me fifteen minutes to bring that monster close enough to the bank so my father could scoop it up in the net. Daddy and I skinned it right there and cooked it over the fire. I can tell you I was proud that day. And Daddy was proud of me too. He kissed me on the mouth four times, one kiss for each pound of that bass. Have you ever made your father that proud of you? I mean, that proud? Four times. He kissed me four times. On the mouth. Have you ever? Four times? On the mouth? *(Beat)* I can show you. It's hard to tell you just how it went unless I show you. That's how proud he was. That's how. Yes. And I closed my eyes because I had to. Because if a worm has seven hearts it could have eight and I wanted him to know I could take it. And I took it. On the mouth. But once it's cut. The worm. You never can tell just which parts have

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been killed and which parts will crawl away and start over because all of the parts are moving. All of the parts are trying to live. But only one or two of them do. Live.

I'll tell you a secret: I'm not a very good daughter. It was worse. His pride in me. Worse. Than eating that worm. Silly, isn't it? Know what I mean? Do you? Four times. On the mouth. That's how it started. Then we went home to tell Mother about my bass.

You wouldn't know it, would you? To look at me. Some of this, here *(Motions to parts of her body, slowly)* isn't really alive anymore. Deceptive, isn't it? How can one look at the body and see nothing but the whole of it. But I know. I know which parts went on and lived and which parts gave up and died. I can tell them apart just by touching them. *(She gently touches herself in different places, not necessarily sexual parts of her body)* Can you tell them apart? If you touch yourself, here and here, or there and there? Go on. Try it. That's it. Can you tell just which parts of you are dead and which parts of you are still alive? *(Beat)* Got it? All right then. When ready. *(Beat)* Let's go fishing.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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